MORE RIGHTS TO BE WRESTED



BY KALPANA VISWANATH

Though there is more awareness among women, to end non-consensual sexual behaviour in public spaces, workplaces and in the digital sphere, we need to shift the burden of safety from their bodies to the institutions of patriarchy

Over 20 years ago, I remember attending a protest carrying a placard with the slogan 'Which part of the word "No" do you not understand?'. As a young woman, that was an extremely powerful line, and it spoke to me. Decades later, the slogan still holds true.

The INDIA TODAY survey on consent centre-stages this as a deep-seated problem even as we see women occupy different roles. The findings demonstrate that women don't feel their voices are heard or their experiences valued when it comes to understanding consent. True consent is not just about a legal 'yes' or 'no' behind closed doors. It is about a woman's right to occupy space, to belong and to move through her life without fear.

For too long, we have viewed women's safety as a matter of protection, locking them away for their own good. Every time there is a gruesome case, women and families become more controlling of freedoms, and this eventually keeps the burden of safety on women's bodies. We must shift the burden to men and to all the institutions that keep patriarchy alive and kicking.

The survey throws up concerning statistics about women's experience of non-consensual sexual behaviour in public spaces, workplaces and digital spaces. Nearly 50 per cent of the respondents experienced unwanted touching, groping and harassment in public spaces. Around 70 per cent said they change their dress, routes or timings to avoid harassment. This is evidence that the fear of violence is as significant as actual violence in constraining women's mobility and freedom.

The digital space today is a public space, with the inequities and violence replicated and compounded. Survey respondents reported unwanted messages even after a refusal, photos shared without permission, unwanted explicit material and stalking.

It is heartening that there is greater awareness among women of their rights, as reflected in their response to violations. When asked what they would do in case of any non-consensual sexual behaviour in public spaces, 37 per cent said they would respond directly, 8 per cent would respond indirectly, 8 per cent would seek help from friends or family and 16 per cent said they would report to the police or a helpline. This is reassuring, as women are not keeping quiet as much as they may have in the past.

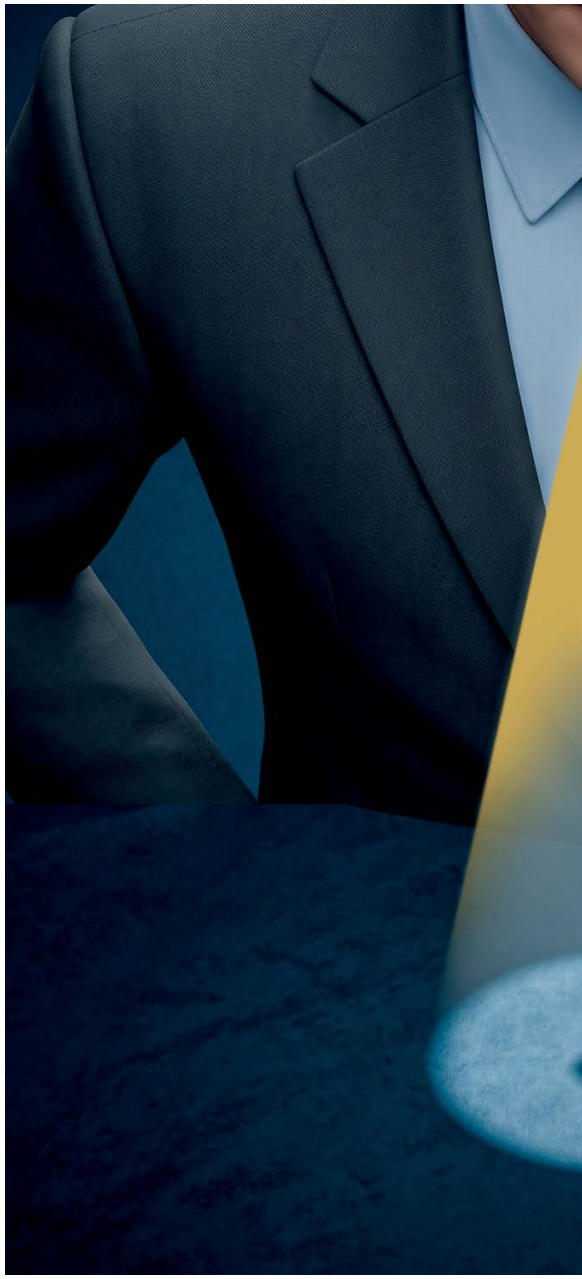


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